

HARDIK CHHABRA

## WHO IS MALLIKARJUN KHARGE?

**The Dalit leader from Karnataka was born on July 21, 1942, in Warawatti, Bidar district. A practising Buddhist, he is the oldest Congress president at 80 years of age. Speaks five languages—English, Hindi, Urdu, Kannada and Marathi—and was a state-level kabaddi and hockey player in his younger days**

### EDUCATION

Went to a Marathi-medium school. An arts graduate from Government College, Kalaburagi, and an LLB, Kharge is a labour law expert who has practised under Shivaraj Patil, who went on to become an SC judge

### POLITICAL ENTRY

Was active in student politics and later with labour unions. Joined the Congress in 1969, the year the then prime minister Indira Gandhi was expelled from the party. He was on her side

### REBELLION

Ten years later, he left the Congress along with mentor and former Karnataka CM Devaraj Urs. Returned to the Congress in 1980. It was the only time Kharge showed a rebel streak

### FIRST POSITION HELD

President of the Kalaburagi Town Congress Committee at the age of 27 in 1969

### TOP POSITIONS HELD

Union railways minister, Leader of the Congress in Lok Sabha, Leader of the Opposition in Rajya Sabha

### ELECTORAL RECORD

Was elected to the Karnataka assembly nine consecutive times (1972-2008). Won the Gulbarga Lok Sabha seat in 2009 and 2014. Came to be known as *solilada sardara* (undefeated chieftain)

### THE BIG DEFEAT

In the 2019 Lok Sabha election, Kharge was defeated by his former election agent Umesh Jadhav, who had become a legislator but had subsequently defected to the BJP

**FAMILY:** Kharge and wife Radhabai have three sons—Priyank, Rahul and Milind—and two daughters—Priyadarshini and Jayashree. Priyank, a Congress MLA and former Karnataka minister, is the only one in politics

**MALLIKARJUN KHARGE IS A STUDY** in contrasts. Of the 13 elections he has contested, including the recently-concluded one for Congress president, he has won 12. Yet, he doesn't have the flamboyance of a mass leader. Thanks to his "gigantic physique"—as a close relative puts it—he comes across as a serious person, but his wicked sense of humour has one in splits during conversations. Most of his political colleagues find him polite and sober but, at home, he is a disciplinarian. "Whenever he is at home, even the grandchildren are on their toes. He asks them questions about everything, from global warming to local civic issues to check their awareness levels. He's also particular about not wasting food, water or electricity," says Priyank Kharge, his son and a Karnataka MLA.

But Kharge, a former sportsperson who excelled in a number of sports in his younger days, is quite indisciplined when it comes to work-life balance. He is known to be a foodie who loves his non-vegetarian fare and jowar roti, but often sits through party meetings and events that run for over half a day without taking a break. But despite the erratic daily routine, Kharge remains agile at 80 with no age-related maladies. In fact, he spent his 80th birthday on the streets of Delhi, protesting against the Enforcement Directorate's questioning of outgoing Con-